The Aliens Win, handoff, October 31 2026

The Aliens Win is an endless arcade shooter played in the browser. The player is a UFO parked near the top of the screen. Stick figure humans hide behind cover in the field below and shoot back. The core idea is that there is no winning. Waves keep coming and get harder until the UFO is destroyed. The owner wants more alien pop culture callbacks over time, such as Men in Black references, on top of the existing TARDIS and Spaceballs Eagle 5 ships.

Live URL: aliens-win.vercel.app. GitHub repo: sudosilo/aliens-win, branch main. The whole game is one file, index.html, about 50 KB of HTML, CSS and plain JavaScript drawn on a single canvas. It uses no frameworks, no build step, no external scripts and no external fonts. The fonts are system fonts, Arial Black or Impact for display text and Courier New for monospace text. The repo also holds README.md and CHANGELOG.md, which the Control Troll scribe writes, and this handoff PDF in the handoff folder. Control Troll checks the app every morning. A release tag v2026.10.11 marks the first version.

Deploys run from GitHub. The Vercel project is linked to the repo with vercel git connect, so any push to main builds production on its own with nothing to run on the phone. To make a change, clone sudosilo/aliens-win, edit index.html, commit, and push to main. Before pushing, fetch origin main and rebase, because the scribe commits README and CHANGELOG updates to the same branch.

Game flow. The menu overlay shows a ship select grid with seven ships, a perk line, and an Initiate Harvest button. The selected ship spins on the menu background. startGame at line 774 applies the ship stats, resets state and calls layoutWave. The game over screen rebuilds the same ship grid with a Try Again button. The game loop wraps update and draw in a try and catch that prints any runtime error in red on the canvas, so crashes show on screen instead of failing silently.

Controls. Each tap or click fires one laser from the UFO toward the tap point. Fire rate equals tap rate. The cannon barrel follows the cursor or finger. The UFO drifts left and right on its own toward a random target every two to five seconds to make it harder to hit. The player does not steer it.

Ships, defined in the SHIPS array at line 80. Each ship has a radius r, an HP multiplier, a shield multiplier, a laser speed, a hitbox offset and a color. GREY MK-I is the balanced purple dish. MOOSHIP 3000 is a cow print saucer with a cow face in the dome, horns, and more HP. NEEDLE-7 is a cyan dart with fast lasers, a tiny hitbox and a weak shield. WRAITH is a dark green triangle with the smallest hitbox. SAUCER PRIME is a gold chrome saucer with a big shield. THE TARDIS is a blue police box with a double shield. EAGLE 5 is the Spaceballs Winnebago with 1.8 times HP, a weak shield and the slowest lasers. Each ship is drawn twice: in drawUFO at line 566 for the game and in drawShipPreview at line 684 for the menu cards. A new ship needs an entry in SHIPS plus a branch in both draw functions. startGame also sets UFO.y per ship, 90 for the TARDIS, 75 for Eagle 5 and 68 for the rest.

Health. The UFO has three layers. The deflector is a cyan arc ring at radius r plus 22. It eats incoming shots, losing 18 charge per shot out of 100, and recharges after a 3 second pause. The shield bar, cyan and second under the UFO, absorbs damage next and recharges 2 seconds after the last hit. The HP bar, green to yellow to red and first under the UFO, never recharges. The game ends when HP reaches zero. Base values are UFO_MAX_HP 200 and UFO_MAX_SHIELD 200 at lines 74 and 75, multiplied per ship. Recharge constants are at lines 96 and 97.

Humans, defined in HTYPES at line 110. There are five types. Basic has 1 HP. Armored has 3 HP and draws a chest plate. Manpack has 2 HP, carries a radio pack and fires a double shot. The mother-in-law has 1 HP, wears a hat and keeps wandering. Spider has 2 HP and spider legs. Every human is assigned to one obstacle and spawns behind it. The AI cycles through four states. In hiding only the head and eyes show above the cover. In peeking the human slides past the edge of the cover and stands up. It fires one shot, then retreats behind the cover again. When its cover is destroyed it switches to panic, standing in the open, drifting side to side and firing about every half second.

Cover, built in layoutWave at line 183. Obstacle types are listed in OBST_TYPES at line 117: car, flipped car, garbage can, house, tree and school bus. Each has a fixed width and height set as plain properties right after it is created. Lasers and enemy shots both stop on cover. Cover has 5 HP at the start. Each hit shakes it, cracks it and starts fire and smoke particles that grow as it weakens. At zero it bursts into confetti and every human behind it panics.

Difficulty scaling, lines 205 to 208. Waves 1 to 4 have 20 humans. From wave 5 the count rises by 2 per wave up to 36. Human fire delay drops 6 percent per wave down to a floor of 45 percent. Damage rises 15 percent per wave. Cover HP rises about 0.8 per wave up to 12. The human type mix also gets tougher at waves 2, 3, 6 and 9. Hide time between peeks and panic fire delay both shrink with each wave. This scaling was added after the owner reached wave 13 too easily.

Alien commentary. Two aliens talk in small speech bubbles at the top of the screen. ZRX speaks in a green bubble on the left. KLN answers in a cyan bubble on the right 2 seconds later, and both stay up 5 seconds. A new exchange starts every 8 seconds on a timer, QUIP_INTERVAL 480 frames at line 99. Cover destruction and wave clears also trigger lines. The quip pools are KILL_QUIPS, COVER_QUIPS, PANIC_QUIPS and WAVE_QUIPS, starting at line 120. Each entry is a pair of strings, the ZRX line and the KLN reply. The tone is crude, foul-mouthed alien contempt aimed at humanity as a species, with jokes about Trinity, cobalt, Roswell, cows, ocean sewage, leaf blowers, canned cheese and podcasts. The aliens never target any ethnic, religious or other group.

Visual style. Black space background with stars, a faint green grid, neon colors, glow effects, and a CRT scanline overlay. Kills throw 50 pieces of confetti and laser hits throw smaller bursts. The HUD shows HP, the title and humans left. Score and wave sit at the bottom corners.

Compatibility rules. The owner plays on Android phones in a WebView. Getter syntax such as get x() inside object literals broke the game twice, once for the UFO and once for obstacle sizes, leaving the screen blank or empty of humans. Keep all object properties plain. The current file uses var and function inside draw loops and avoids newer syntax in hot paths. Check every change with a syntax pass and a headless browser run that starts each ship and confirms humans spawn before pushing. That test passed for all ships on October 11.

Bug history, to avoid repeating. A stray closing brace left by an edit closed update early. An earlier edit replaced the ship stat assignment in startGame with a comment, so HP and shield were never set. The original start button reference went dead after the game over screen rewrote the overlay, which is why the current code looks buttons up by id each time. After these, the game was rewritten in one clean pass, and that rewrite is the version on GitHub.

Next ideas the owner raised. Add more alien movie and TV callbacks, such as Men in Black, as ships, enemies or quips. Keep tuning difficulty so later waves overwhelm the player. Trapdoor spider humans that pop up from the ground were in the original concept but are not built yet. The game has no sound, no saved high scores, and no connection to the owner's shared score service.